Kramer (2010), Smith (1991, 1999, 2007), South (2008), and others do offer more nuanced and detailed research into conflicts in Myanmar. While still seeing them through an 'ethnic lens', their treatment illustrates the point that 'ethnicities' should not be seen in terms of static, binary social categories, but as complex social realities. As Brubaker (1998, 2004) argues, ethnicity is not about distinct social groupings but dynamic social relationships and sets of historically framed processes. We argue that it is more useful to think about 'ethnicity without groups', or about nation-ness as a set of contingencies, discursive frames, political projects, or organizational routines than as groups of people. Static definitions of ethnicity that categorize individuals and groups not only reify group and individual relations, but also become a form of oppression, caging individuals into involuntary associations and groups into unmalleable identities (Malešević 2004). It is important to treat 'ethnicities' as categories of social practice, not discrete and static entities with clearly defined membership.

There has been a long academic debate about the causes and characteristics of conflict. 'Ethnic' conflict, as the conflicts in Myanmar have long been framed, is almost always perceived as a form of 'grievance', around issues such as ethnic structural violence (Geertz 1973; Horowitz 1985), incompatible cultural values (Huntington 1996), or loss of identity (Sen 2006). Since the influential work of Collier and Hoeffler (1998, 2002), rejection of ethnicity as a driver has often been used as a means to categorize conflict as driven by 'greed' motives, such as competition over scarce resources (Homer-Dixon 1994), or contestation of the control of economic opportunity (Collier et al. 2003), including the 'resource curse' (Le Billon 2001). However, our questioning of the 'ethnic' categorization of the Kachin conflict does not inherently constitute an argument for 'greed' motives around resources, but a plea to look beyond simplistic, binary categorization.

Our recent research confirms that most Kachin (and most others) discussing the conflict do so in terms of 'ethnicity' and identity. There is thus a need to explore the historically framed processes and ideological underpinnings of this framing as social practice, where ideology is seen as a process that incorporates thinking and action in order to produce cognitive maps that influence human behaviour (Williams 1988). Exploration of the historical and ideological narratives employed in legitimization and mobilization is a practical way to do so. As the contents of ideological discourses are informed by imagined ideal social orders that invoke